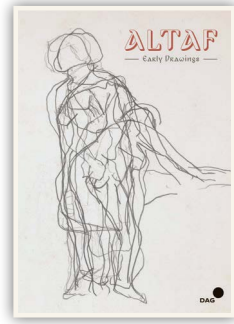
Edited by Altaf's daughter Sasha Altaf, an illustrated volume of these diaries has been brought out by DAG along with a companion volume of Altaf's early drawings. The quite powerful drawings, paintings and political imagery made in the artist's mature years have perhaps received less attention than the work of some his contemporaries such as Khakar, Malani, Sundaram and his sister Nasreen; the early student sketches and life studies we see in the *Journals* volume are not particularly startling; what is fascinating, however, is the daily record of a supremely alert young mind and spirit that is hungry to engage with the world of art and ideas.

What's fascinating about the ***Journals*** volume is the daily record of a supremely alert young mind and spirit that is hungry to engage with the world of art and ideas



Altaf writes beautifully, and the first part of the book gives us one great cross-section of London in the early 1960s. Many things will ring a bell for those of us who made similar forays to western cities later, the novelty of the constant availability of all kinds of cultural production, the changes in the weather, the ups and downs of a local politics that affect the whole world, the homesickness and the fleeting visits of friends.

Even though every day seems to be filled with activity, the self-conscious young man writes: "*I am passing a life of complete idleness—idleness that suffocates me and, yet, all my fight against this sickness is 'invitation'—what a complete hypocrite I am!*"

Interspersed among the lists of films seen, books read and galleries visited is a growing political consciousness. He's quite sharp about Churchill and ahead of the curve when he pricks the hero-worship and eulogies inspired by the racist imperialist at his death: "*Even today the English do well to keep his ideas on colonialism and the 'British Empire' in the dark. What blasphemy they commit by calling Churchill 'The Champion of Freedom'. Of England, yes. Of Europe, yes. Of the West, yes but of the 'World', good god, no...*"

Occasionally, the young man delivers a great turn of phrase: "*...the rain is still hiding itself behind the clouds*" or "*Lost my job, gained the sky and sunshine*". At other moments he struggles, as sensitive young people often do with the fallout of observing themselves too much: "*To my horror, I realise that I have forgotten how to think. I do not think, I merely form opinions. Mostly my ideas are begotten from books, my job is either to accept or to reject them.*"

Back in India, the diary becomes more of a daily list of things done and people encountered. One's fascination with that time continues to be watered, however, when you read a single line from June 13: "*Music recital by Kumar Gandharva—brilliant!*" and then, just below, another single line from August 20: "*Met Ritwik Ghatak.*" ■

Ruchir Joshi



It took Das two years of dedicated study and research and four years of actual drawing to create the 26 large-format artworks on display

dium to capture the interplay of light and shadow, conveying a sense of both strength and elegance that resonates with viewers on a spiritual level," says Das.

Creating the horse drawings came with the aforementioned technical challenge so beloved of artists, "such as achieving precise details in the intricate anatomy of the horse while managing the inherent smudging nature of charcoal". "Maintaining a balance between capturing the expressive qualities of the medium and ensuring the accuracy of equine features demanded careful control over strokes, shading, and erasing," says Das.

The result is stunning works of art you can only gawp at, transfixed by Das's mastery of the form and, further, awe at that "immortal hand or eye" that framed this "fearful symmetry".

It took Das two years of dedicated study and research and four years of actual drawing to create the 26 large-format artworks on display. As an artist, Das is at a pivotal moment in his creative journey, "transitioning from traditional acrylic and oil on canvas to digital painting". "Currently, I'm delving into an innovative project that involves AI-based art creation...By exploring the intersection of artificial intelligence and artistic intuition, I strive to push the boundaries of creativity," he says. ■

Amit Dixit

Savage Beauty *runs from December 14 to 19 at the Visual Arts Gallery, India Habitat Centre, New Delhi*